

Name: _____

Date: _____

Growing Up in Roman Britain

Year 4 reading comprehension · Information text · 12 marks · About 20 minutes

A different world

Almost two thousand years ago, Britain was part of the Roman Empire. Roman soldiers, traders and families lived in towns such as Londinium, which is now London. Children growing up there had a very different life from children today.

School days

Not every child went to school. Families who could pay sent their sons to school at about the age of seven. Pupils wrote on wooden tablets covered in wax, using a pointed tool called a stylus. If they made a mistake, they simply smoothed the wax and started again. Many girls and children from poorer families did not go to school. Some girls from wealthy families were taught to read and write at home.

Time to play

Roman children still found time to play. They rolled hoops, spun tops and played board games with counters. One popular game used knucklebones, which were small bones from sheep or goats. Players tossed them into the air and tried to catch them on the back of the hand.

Rich and poor homes

Wealthy children lived in houses with painted walls and warm floors, heated by a system called a hypocaust. Poorer children often lived in small, crowded rooms, many of them in or above shops. Many children began helping their families with work while they were still young.

1. Which modern city was built on the Roman town of Londinium? (1 mark)

2. At about what age did boys from families who could pay start school? (1 mark)

3. What did Roman pupils write on? (1 mark)

4. Find and copy one word that names the tool pupils used to write on the wax. (1 mark)

5. Why was a wax tablet useful for someone learning to write? (2 marks)

6. Which two groups of children often did not go to school? (2 marks)

7. The text says poorer children “often lived in small, crowded rooms” and “began helping their families with work”. Why do you think they started work while still young? (2 marks)

8. The text says Roman children had “a very different life from children today”. Give one way their lives were different. Use the text to explain your answer. (2 marks)

Writing task: Imagine you are a Roman child in Londinium. Write a paragraph about your day.
